

openclaw/imshow vs imshow-mcp: feature and UX sweep

Research wave R1a, 2026-10-08. Their repo pinned at commit d604a8be548a637faa35fe968af426c7484ded67 (v0.15.10).

Ours: EQStack 91b08bb.

1. Executive summary

The most important finding: openclaw/imshow is not an MCP server. A repo-wide case-insensitive search for “mcp” finds one hit, in an unrelated Swift source file (Sources/IMsgCore/MessageStore+ServiceAvailability.swift @ d604a8b). It is a Swift CLI (imshow) plus a **JSON-RPC 2.0 over stdio** server (imshow rpc, docs/rpc.md:1-9 @ d604a8b) that OpenClaw supervises as a child process (docs/rpc.md:99 @ d604a8b). So the comparison is “their CLI+RPC surface” against “our MCP tools + CLI + TUI”. We win on agent ergonomics (typed MCP tools, thread slugs, resolve-by-name, media understanding, export, analytics, humans files, prompt-injection wrapping). They win on **send honesty, resumable cursors, capability/permission diagnostics, reaction/poll/scheduled coverage, and distribution polish.**

Their biggest strategic split: everything that needs IMCore injection (read receipts, typing, edit, unsend, threaded replies, stickers, polls, group management, effects) requires **SIP disabled** (README.md:87-89, docs/advanced-imcore.md @ d604a8b). Their SIP-free surface (chats, history, search, watch, stats, AppleScript send, UI-scripted tapbacks) is the part that is portable to our no-SIP posture. Most “adopt” items below come from that half.

Top 10 adopt-now (ranked by value over effort for a no-SIP MCP product):

#	Item and one-line reason	Effort	Their evidence
1	Typed delivery disposition on every failed/uncertain send (not_started retry-safe, may_have_completed, still_in_flight) plus retry_safe boolean. We return delivered failed pending but give agents no retry contract; double-sends are the worst agent failure.	S-M	docs/send.md:72-98, docs/rpc.md:123-136
2	Tahoe (macOS 26) ghost-row detection after AppleScript send (success reported, empty unjoined SMS row written). We have no equivalent; grep of our src/ finds none.	S	docs/send.md:113-122
3	Resumable cursor API: since_rowid in, next_rowid and has_more out, plus a terminal overflow notice carrying resume_after_rowid. Our wait_for_changes is push-fed but gives agents no durable cursor to survive restarts.	M	docs/rpc.md:304-345, docs/watch.md:25-45, 104-120
4	One status snapshot: per-gate readiness (Full Disk Access, Automation, Contacts), DB feature flags, methods usable right now , never launching anything. Ours: doctor CLI and dev-only health_check; no always-on MCP preflight.	S-M	docs/rpc.md:155-207, docs/permissions.md:94-98
5	Standard tapback send (six kinds) via UI automation, verified by waiting for the new outgoing reaction row in chat.db. We read reactions but cannot send any.	M	docs/send.md:124-141, CHANGELOG.md 0.15.8-0.15.9
6	Fail-closed request validation: unknown keys rejected, strict types, explicit alias lists. Our Zod output schemas are not .strict() (grep finds no .strict() in src/mcp-schemas.ts); verify input side before acting.	S	docs/rpc.md:22-48
7	Return the sent message’s id + guid on send, and keep verification scoped to the actual route after SMS fallback. We return lastMessageId already (partial); add guid and route.	S	docs/rpc.md:519-552, docs/send.md:100-111
8	Search quality: Unicode case-insensitive, literal % _ \, matches attributed bodies and stored audio transcripts , each physical message once across linked chats, match: exact contains. Add exact mode and transcript matching to search_messages.	S	docs/rpc.md:283-302
9	Group attachment sends: they stage into ~/Library/Messages/Attachments/imshow/ and send to chat id for groups. Our docs say file sends to groups are unreliable (1-on-1 only). Test their staging path in our sender.	M	docs/groups.md Sending to a group, docs/attachments.md:60-70
10	URL-preview balloon coalescing in history/search/watch (text row + later URLBalloonProvider row folded into one	S-M	docs/json.md:110-120, docs/watch.md:149-151

	message with a url_preview object). We classify balloon types but I found no coalescing (not verified in depth).	
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Honourable mentions (adopt-later): completions llm generated agent reference, scheduled-message read, native poll read model, multi-number routing diagnostics, Homebrew/notarized distribution, docs site.

2. Method, limits and diagram tooling

- Cloned --depth 1 to openclaw-imsig/ (workdir ../scratchpad/research/r1a), HEAD d604a8be548a637faa35fe968af426c7484ded67. Read README, all 19 files in docs/, CHANGELOG.md, command specs under Sources/imsig/Commands/, gh release list, and gh issue list (3 open issues: 334 bridge helper lookup list, 332 arbitrary-emoji tapback send, 328 SSH AddressBook delegate-contact precedence).
- Ours: apps/imsig-mcp/{AGENTS.md, README.md, docs/T00LS.md, src/mcp-tools.ts}, docs/STATUS.md @ 91b08bb. Read only.
- **Not verified:** I did not build or run imsig (no Swift build, no live Messages). Everything about their behaviour is from their docs and source text, not execution. Claims about macOS 26/27 behaviour are theirs. Internals (algorithms, structure) are R1b's. No personal data is quoted.
- Diagram tools: command -v d2 dot mmdc plantuml found none. The overlap map in section 4 is drawn with native Typst grid cells (no external packages), so it compiles offline.
- Issue/release data: GitHub CLI; the open-issue list shows only three, so user-pain evidence is thin and mostly comes from CHANGELOG.md fix entries.

3. Their surface at a glance

Distribution: Homebrew tap steipete/tap/imsig; signed, notarized universal macOS binary; Linux x86_64 read-only archive (docs/install.md:5-30, release assets imsig-macos.zip, imsig-linux-x86_64.tar.gz). macOS 14+. No daemon, no Node (docs/install.md "What you don't need").

CLI commands (from Sources/imsig/Commands/*.swift abstracts @ d604a8b): chats, group, history, search, watch, stats, scheduled, status, account, whois, nickname, name-photo, chat-background, completions, rpc, launch, send, react; SIP-gated: read, typing, send-rich, send-multipart, send-attachment, send-sticker, tapback, edit, unsend, delete-message, notify-anyways, poll send|vote|unvote, chat-create, chat-name, chat-photo, chat-add-member, chat-remove-member, chat-leave, chat-delete, chat-mark.

RPC methods (docs/rpc.md @ d604a8b): initialize, status, chats.list, chats.create, messages.history, messages.search, messages.after, messages.scheduled, messages.stats, watch.subscribe/unsubscribe, bridge.events.subscribe, send, send.tracked, send.rich, send.attachment, send.multipart, message.send_status, tapback, message.edit/unsend/delete/notifyAnyways, group.setIcon, handles.check, poll methods, sticker, contact-card methods.

Config surfaces: essentially flags and IMSIG_* env (e.g. IMSIG_LAUNCH_READY_TIMEOUT, CHANGELOG.md 0.15.2); --db path flag everywhere; no config file found. Contrast ours: config.json, credentials.json, setup wizard.

Output contract: --json is NDJSON, human text on stderr only (README.md:73, docs/json.md:11); numeric selectors validated up front (README.md:75).

4. Feature-overlap map

Theirs only (we lack)	Both	Ours only (they lack)
Tapback send (UI-scripted, verified)	List chats, history, date/participant filters	Real MCP server (18 typed tools, resources)
Typed retry-safe delivery dispositions	Search (theirs: exact/contains; ours: fuzzy+literal)	Thread slugs, merged cross-handle identity
Ghost-row detection (macOS 26)	Live watch (kqueue WAL + poll fallback)	resolve_conversation / resolve_handle
Resumable ROWID cursor (messages.after)	AppleScript text send + SMS/iMessage routing	Media interpretation chain + cache
Capability/permission status snapshot	Attachment metadata + path resolution	Export (md/csv/json/ndjson, streaming)
Scheduled (Send Later) read	Attributed-body text recovery	Analytics (7 types), humans files
Native poll read model	Contacts name resolution from AddressBook	Interactive TUI
Multi-number routing diagnostics	Group detection, participants	Group system events (rename/add/leave)
Chat background status	Reaction read (watch / change events)	Edit history read, prompt-injection wrapping
completions llm / shell completions	Aggregate stats	wait_for_reply with echo suppression
Brew + notarized binary, docs site	Read-only DB mode on fixtures / Linux	Setup wizard, host config writer
SIP-gated: edit, unsend, replies, stickers, group mgmt, typing, read		

Figure 1: Feature-overlap map. Green: both have it. Red: only openclaw/imgsg. Blue: only imgsg-mcp. Grey: needs SIP-off injection, out of scope.

5. Full comparison table

Verdict key: **L** = we lack it, **T** = theirs better, **O** = ours better, = equal. Triage: *now*, *later*, *skip*. Effort S/M/L. Their cites are path:line @ #sha; ours cite apps/imgsg-mcp paths @ 91b08bb.

Feature	Theirs	Ours	V	Triage	Reason	Eff
Read chats list	chats --limit --unread-only; unread_count (docs/chats.md:82)	list_conversations with slugs, snippets, unread (src/mcp-tools.ts:309)	O	skip	Ours richer; unread_only filter is trivial to add.	-
Read history	history filters applied before limit; date/participants (docs/history.md)	get_messages, cursor beforeMessageId, hasMore (docs/TOOLS.md Reading)	=	skip	Equivalent.	-
Resumable catch-up	messages.after: since_rowid -> next_rowid,has_more (docs/rpc.md:304)	None public; internal high-water ROWID (docs/STATUS.md section 9)	T	now	Agents need durable cursors across restarts.	M
Search	search --query --match exact contains, Unicode case, transcripts (docs/rpc.md:283)	search_messages fuzzy+literal (src/mcp-tools.ts:331)	=	now	Add exact mode + transcript matching only.	S
Live watch	watch kqueue + poll fallback, debounce, --reactions, backpressure (docs/watch.md)	wait_for_changes, WAL watcher + 10s poll (docs/STATUS.md section 9)	=	later	Port overflow-resume contract with the cursor item.	M
Await reply	None (build from watch)	wait_for_reply w/ self-interjections, echo suppression (src/mcp-tools.ts:216)	O	skip	Ours unique.	-
Send text	send with verification, service select, region (docs/send.md)	send_message routes on real thread service (AGENTS.md Sending)	T	now	Verified row + typed disposition (top-10 #1,#2,#7).	S-M
Service override	--service auto message sms, --no-sms-fallback (docs/send.md:72)	Auto only, no override arg	T	later	Expose service + fallback toggle for power users.	S
Phone region	--region ISO code (docs/send.md)	handle-normal.ts (no per-call region; unverified)	T	later	Cheap arg.	S
Attachment send	--file, staged copy, groups ok (docs/attachments.md:60)	attachments[], staged in imgsg-mcp-staging, 1-on-1 only (docs/TOOLS.md)	T	now	Try group path; verify with receipt join.	M
Voice message send	--audio CAF/Opus via afconvert, bridge only (docs/attachments.md:80)	None	L	skip	Needs SIP-off bridge.	L
Tapback send	Six kinds, UI automation + DB confirm (docs/send.md:124)	Read only (analytics + events)	L	now	Common agent expression; needs Accessibility.	M
Arbitrary emoji tapback	Rejected; open issue #332	None	=	skip	No reliable surface exists.	-
Reply to message	Native threaded reply, bridge only (docs/bridge.md)	Reads ReplyContext (src/reply-preview.ts)	O/L	skip	Read yes, write needs SIP-off.	L

Feature	Theirs	Ours	V	Triage	Reason	Eff
Edit / unsend	Bridge only (docs/bridge.md:Message and chat mutation)	Edit history read (src/edit-history.ts)	O	skip	Reading is the reachable half.	-
Effects, subjects, rich text, stickers, multipart	Bridge only	None	L	skip	SIP-off.	L
Polls	Create/vote bridge-only; read model in history/watch (docs/json.md)	None	L	later	Read-only poll decode is SIP-free; niche.	M
Scheduled messages	scheduled list, messages.scheduled (docs/rpc.md:347)	None	L	later	SIP-free read; useful to avoid double-send.	S
Group management	Create/rename/photo/add/remove/leave/delete, bridge-only	None; reads system events (get_conversation_events)	O/L	skip	SIP-off.	L
Group events read	Not found in docs (unknown)	get_conversation_events (src/mcp-tools.ts:284)	O	skip	Ours unique.	-
Mark read / typing	Bridge only (docs/advanced-imcore.md)	None	L	skip	SIP-off.	L
Reachability check	handles.check IDS via bridge (docs/rpc.md:663)	check_imessage_availability best-effort from history (src/mcp-tools.ts:477)	T	skip	Real IDS needs SIP-off; ours honest about limits.	-
Contacts	Contacts.framework + SSH AddressBook fallback (docs/permissions.md:73)	AddressBook DB direct, merge across sources (docs/CONTACT_MERGE_AND_SLUGS.md)	O	skip	Ours merges identities; theirs has open delegate bug #328.	-
Name -> thread	None (use chats + jq)	resolve_conversation, contact:N selectors	O	skip	Ours unique.	-
Stats/analytics	stats totals, per chat/sender/date, --media (docs/stats.md)	chat_analytics 7 types + cache	O	later	Add media-bytes breakdown only.	S
Export	None (use history + jq)	export_messages md/csv/json/ndjson, streaming	O	skip	Ours unique.	-
Attachment access	Metadata, path, --convert-attachments via ffmpeg (docs/attachments.md:36)	get_attachment image blocks, posters, interpretation chain	O	skip	Ours unique.	-
URL preview folding	Folds balloon rows (docs/json.md:110)	Balloon type classify only (unverified)	T	now	Avoid duplicate rows in reads.	S-M
Routing diagnostics	account_id, account_login, destination_caller_id (docs/groups.md)	None found in src/	L	later	Helps multi-number setups.	S
Status / doctor	status + typed RPC error codes (docs/rpc.md:155)	doctor CLI, dev health_check	T	now	Always-available MCP preflight.	S-M
Strict validation	Unknown keys rejected (docs/rpc.md:22)	Zod; strictness unverified	T	now	Fail-closed inputs.	S
Prompt-injection hygiene	Not found (unknown)	wrapUntrusted (src/mcp-format.ts:101)	O	skip	Ours unique.	-
Shell completions + LLM ref	completions bash/zsh/fish/llm from one spec (docs/completions.md:42)	imgsg tools, hand-written TOOLS.md	T	later	Generate TOOLS.md from tool defs.	S
Linux / offline DB	Read-only Linux archive (docs/linux.md)	VITE_ENV=ai mocks + fixtures (AGENTS.md Env layout)	=	later	Document --db-style read-only mode.	S
TUI	None	Full Ink TUI	O	skip	Ours unique.	-
Install	Brew, notarized binary (docs/install.md)	npk -y, .mcpb bundle (README.md Install)	=	later	Brew tap for the CLI/TUI; low urgency.	M
Docs	imgsg.sh site, per-topic pages, troubleshooting map	README + TOOLS.md + WORKFLOWS.md	T	later	Add troubleshooting-by-symptom page.	S
Concurrency/lane model	FIFO mutation lane, 4 concurrent reads, poison on in-flight (docs/rpc.md:101-140)	30s tool timeouts, no lane model	T	later	Design is R1b territory; UX point: block sends after uncertain one.	M

6. UX and discoverability lessons

- Onboarding names the exact gate.** Their permissions page maps each failure to one of three gates (Full Disk Access, Automation, Contacts) in a table (docs/permissions.md:94-98 @ d604a8b) and says grant the **parent process**, relaunch, and toggle off/on for stale TCC records (docs/permissions.md:100). Our README lists the three permissions but not stale-grant or parent-process advice (README.md Permissions). Lift both into doctor output.
- Degrade, do not die.** imgsg rpc starts without database access; initialize and status still answer and DB methods return typed retryable -32002 (docs/rpc.md:18-20,54-56). An MCP server that comes up with FDA missing and **explains itself through a tool** beats a host showing “server failed to start”.
- Silence is never success.** Their react and send now refuse to report success unless they observe the new outgoing row (CHANGELOG.md 0.15.8, docs/send.md:100). Same principle as our status: pending; theirs adds the typed no-retry rule.
- Errors carry a retry contract, not prose.** “Never infer retry safety from human-readable error text” (docs/bridge.md:215-232). Put retry_safe in structuredContent.
- Defaults are explicit and documented per surface.** CLI debounce 250 ms vs RPC 500 ms with the reason stated (docs/rpc.md:397). Document why each of our timeouts differs (src/mcp-tools.ts:96-105).

6. **Self-describing CLI for models.** completions llm emits a Markdown reference generated from the same CommandSpec the parser uses, so docs cannot drift (docs/completions.md:42-50). Our T00LS.md is hand-written; scripts/check-docs-integrity.mjs partly covers drift.
7. **Help is example-first.** Every spec carries usageExamples (Sources/ormsg/Commands/BridgeIntroCommands.swift:27 @ d604a8b), and the README's pitch is four one-liners (README.md:15-20). Our README leads with install JSON; consider a four-line "first five minutes" block.
8. **Stdout is machine-only.** Progress and warnings to stderr; NDJSON on stdout (docs/json.md:11). Our MCP stdio server already needs this; check our CLI --json honours it (unverified).
9. **Troubleshooting is symptom-indexed** (docs/troubleshooting.md): "Sends report success but never arrive", "watch goes silent", "Contacts names are missing". Ours has get_last_send_error but no symptom page.
10. **Honest limits stated up front.** "Cannot force a specific outgoing number" (docs/send.md:143-148), "react cannot guarantee a specific message target" (docs/send.md:130). We should publish equivalent limits for group file sends.
11. **Caveat:** their user pain is visible in CHANGELOG fixes, not issues (only 3 open). Repeated themes: macOS-version fragility of UI/AppleScript paths (0.15.9), Contacts stalls blocking watch (0.15.6), bridge startup races (0.15.2-0.15.3). Expect the same for our tapback and attachment work.

7. Open questions for George

1. Is any SIP-off feature in scope (replies, edit, unsend, polls, group management)? If not, mark all "bridge" rows permanently *skip*.
2. Tapback send needs UI scripting and so Accessibility permission (we already treat Accessibility as opt-in, README.md Permissions). Acceptable as another opt-in?
3. Do we want a cursor-based catch-up tool (get_messages_after) alongside wait_for_changes, or fold the cursor into the existing events payload?
4. Should send_message stay "route on the thread's real service" or expose their service and allow_sms_fallback knobs?
5. Does OpenClaw consume only their RPC (so are they a **consumer** of our surface later, requiring an RPC-compatible adapter)? Unknown from this repo.
6. Unknown, to verify before building: whether our sender already detects ghost rows; whether our MCP input schemas reject unknown keys; whether group file sends actually work via staged path on current macOS.